

From Preaching to **PRACTICE**

Government apathy. Public cynicism. Corporate greed. Some individuals and institutions have let nothing come in the way of cutting edge solutions.

| By Kaveree Bamzai |

This is how other nations build themselves, block by block, alphabet by alphabet. In 1868, as part of its restoration, the government of Japan set up an education committee, forming several sub-groups to examine how students were educated in different parts of the world. On returning, they created a 200-year education plan for Japan and within the next 40 years, Japan became the first Asian country to become 100 per cent literate. In China, more recently, after the chaos of the cultural revolution, Deng Xiaoping re-introduced the university system. There was a large-scale upgrade of colleges to universities,

campuses were built in a frenzied fashion, universities were merged and enrolment was expanded on a mass scale. The result: if in 1977, only one in 32 students could enter university, by 2003, the number increased to 13.2 per cent.

Not to say that large numbers of those graduates are not now unemployed, but the lesson is that education doesn't need short-term solutions or quick fix announcements. It doesn't need shifting goalposts and lowered standards. It needs a constant commitment to young people and a belief in the future. As Sam Pitroda, who heads the soon-to-be-disbanded National Knowledge Commission says, education models the world-over are 200 years old. We have to now plan for the university and school of 2050. Much of this long-term thinking is possible in

theory by the government, which at Rs 44,528 crore a year remains the biggest spender in the field, but which in practice gets bogged down by petty politics. But as the following pages show, a handful of individuals can also usher change.

At the heart of the transformation has to be the drive to make every child a productive youngster. And to resolve the paradox of what economist A.K. Shivakumar points out is the children of rich going to public universities and the children of poor going to private money-squeezing institutes. Many of these have become second-rate institutes that turn out second-rate students, condemning the peripheral to further periphery. Listen, for instance, to what one Gargi College student wrote to NCERT Director Krishna Kumar in a B.Ed class he was taking:



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